But that evening – perhaps because I was mixing my drinks – I insulted people in the bar, including Monde's buddies.

Eventually the bar manager phoned the Proteas bowling coach and my good friend Vinnie Barnes to come and get me. I know there were some reports that Graeme Smith and some of the players had come to fetch me, but it was Vinnie who hauled me up to my room.

So … by 8 p.m. I was in bed and gone for all the money you know. The next morning I couldn't remember a thing. I played the T20 game that evening, scoring a quick-fire 18 runs off 10 balls before being bowled, stupidly getting an inside edge off a somewhat wide ball.

The next day I faced the music with Mickey and Doc. I was dropped from the squad with immediate effect and either had to pack my bags and check into rehab, or my international career was over. Not much choice then, really.

I remember feeling very frustrated, because, despite what Mickey and Doc were saying to me, I didn't think that I had a problem. I believed my drinking was no different from that of the other guys in the team. You know, when the guys party, it's not like they have one or two beers – if they are going to drink, they are going to go the full hog. If they want to drink 20 beers, they'll drink 20 beers. Mickey was adamant, though, assuring me that no one else was behaving the way I was. Obviously I had to take what he said on board …

I phoned my manager, Donné – man, I've put her through some tough shit – to tell her about the whole deal, and she was in tears. Donné had obviously suspected that my drinking had got out of hand, and she was quite emotional about it. She's a very considerate person and has always had nothing but my best interests at heart. In fact, Donné has always been far more than just my agent or business manager.

On this occasion, she asked me straight: 'Do *you* think you have a problem?' I said to her, 'No, I don't think so. Just because when I drink, I drink a lot more than the other guys doesn't mean I have a problem.'

But she wasn't buying it either. She was brutally honest. Donné said: 'Listen, Hersch, this is *it*. You're not going to play for South Africa again. You've got to give this some very serious thought. I think you need to get help, because you are throwing your life and your career away.'

At this point it's appropriate to tell you a little more about my agent, manager and guardian angel … Donné Commins. Donné has been like a big